girdles of gold set in precious stones, a pair of golden vases, a horse with a saddle set in gold and rubies, 150 more horses, fifty camels and four carpets ‘each of which was worth 2000 crowns’.

At the same time, the Subedar of Bengal sent 300 elephants. This was no ordinary courtier, but Raja Man Singh himself, who had been transferred from Bihar to Bengal in 1594. He had recently concluded a successful expedition against Kedar Rai of Jessore, whose tutelary deity he had seized. Man Singh had seen the image of Sila Mata in a dream, floating underwater. He interpreted this omen as a divine order to seize Kedar Rai’s black stone idol of Sila Mata and build a temple for it. Man Singh would bring back the idol with him when he returned to Amer in 1608 where he would have it ceremoniously installed at a small, north-facing temple in Amer palace where it remains to this day, a symbol of Kachhwaha victory. Thus Man Singh expertly denied Kedar Rai not only his own natal territory but also his protective goddess. To ensure that the goddess continued to be worshipped the way she used to be, and presumably so that she would transfer her blessings to Man Singh, he brought back ten Brahmin priests from Jessore to Amer, where they served the goddess with daily blood sacrifices; descendants of these priests were recorded in Amer till the twentieth century. This episode explains the significant and rather surprising Bengali population of Jaipur.

Man Singh shifted the capital of Bengal away from Tanda, site of Munim Khan’s disastrous and plague-ridden campaign. The new site Man Singh had chosen was strategically significant. It was the site, long guarded by the Gaur Sultans, considered the ancient pass to Bengal, today in a city called Rajmahal, in present day Bihar. It was also the place where Akbar’s forces had defeated the last Afghan ruler of Bengal, finally anchoring this site as a Mughal stronghold. When Man Singh first proposed the name Rajnagar for the site, clearly after himself, Akbar was not convinced and ordered the city renamed Akbarnagar, showing the limits of even a powerful mansabdar’s prerogative. Today, only Mughal texts contain the name Akbarnagar while the populace still refers to the site as Rajmahal, in stubborn recognition of their charismatic Rajput patron. Man Singh also built a Mughal Jami mosque in Akbarnagar. Local traditions claim Man Singh wished to build a temple, but Akbar ordered him to build a mosque which would better suit the requirements of this distant and troublesome outpost. If that was the case, then the raja, undaunted, ‘accepted this order